# Inspection of North Somerset local authority children's services

**Inspection dates:** 21 September to 2 October 2026

**Lead inspector:** Zafer Yilkan, His Majesty's Inspector

| **Judgement** | **Grade** |
|---|---|
| The impact of leaders on social work practice with children and families | Good |
| The experiences and progress of children who need help and protection | Requires improvement to be good |
| The experiences and progress of children in care | Good |
| The experiences and progress of care leavers | Good |

The experiences of children, young people and their families living in North Somerset have significantly improved since the previous inspection in 2023, when the overall effectiveness of services was judged 'requires improvement to be good'. Leaders have created the right conditions, environment and culture within children's services, and as a result, core social work practice across children's services has been substantially improved. Support and services for children in care are now good, and services and support for care leavers have been further strengthened. Leaders know that there is scope for further improvement in some areas of social work practice, specifically around decision-making and managing risk for some children who need help and protection.

North Somerset children's services benefits from ambitious and visible leadership that is committed to keeping children's needs at the heart of strategic planning, vision and service development. The director of children's services (DCS) and both political and corporate leaders have been effective in providing strong and stable leadership, with a clear focus on improving outcomes for children. They have effective oversight of practice and performance and take timely action when weaknesses are identified.

North Somerset is developing a more permanent, stable and motivated workforce that is passionate about improving children's lives. Positively, and as a result, children have had fewer changes of social workers. However, children's attendance

and active participation in influencing corporate parenting panel remains underdeveloped.

**What needs to improve?[1]**

- The consistency and robustness of decision-making for children at the 'front door', out of hours and within the Public Law Outline. (Outcome 2, national framework)
- The response to children who go missing from home and care, and children who are at risk of exploitation or experiencing harm outside the home. (Outcome 3, national framework)
- The response to children in care and care leavers who present with emotional and mental health needs. (Enabler, multi-agency working, national framework)
- The effectiveness of the corporate parenting panel and how well children in care and care leavers help influence, shape and design support and services delivered to children in North Somerset. (Enabler, effective leadership, national framework)

**The experiences and progress of children who need help and protection: requires improvement to be good**

1. When initial requests for help and support are made, most children receive timely and effective responses from the front door. Children's needs are considered well, and managers provide clear guidance to inform multi-agency screening and next steps. Social workers are persistent in their efforts to engage parents, to gather their views to progress multi-agency information-sharing. Managers oversee and agree decisions, which are underpinned by a clear rationale. As a result, many children and their families receive the right response to meet their needs at the earliest time.

2. For a small number of children, decision-making at the front door does not accurately reflect their needs or situations. Their histories and past interventions are not fully understood to identify patterns of repeat assessments and which service is best placed to meet their needs. As a result, some children are inappropriately stepped down to early help support, leading to repeat referrals for statutory social care and their needs not being responded to effectively.

3. Children and families can access a broad range of early help services to help meet their needs. Leaders have taken effective action to address the recent

[1] The areas for improvement have been cross-referenced with the outcomes, enablers or principles in the Children's Social Care: National Framework. This statutory guidance sets out the purpose, principles for practice and expected outcomes of children's social care.

delays some families were experiencing in receiving the support they need to prevent their circumstances from deteriorating.

4. When children require help and protection out of office hours, the response from the emergency duty service (EDT) is not sufficiently robust. Serious safeguarding concerns do not always trigger a strategy discussion, and when they do, planning to secure the immediate safety of the child is not sufficiently robust. Day services swiftly pick up and address these safeguarding concerns.

5. When there are concerns that children are at risk of harm or have suffered significant harm, multi-agency strategy meetings and child protection enquiries are timely and effective. Past, current and future harms are explored to understand children's experiences, and proportionate next steps are agreed, including what actions are needed to keep children safer. Planning is appropriately used and acted on with most parents and children while these enquiries are ongoing.

6. Most social work assessments are sufficiently detailed and provide insight into children's needs and lives. Presenting risks and needs are well identified. However, a small number of children's past histories, families' key strengths and parents' capacity to sustain changes are not fully understood. Social workers are alert to the signs and impact of domestic abuse on children. Referrals to domestic abuse services are made for victims, perpetrators and children so they can receive specialist support to meet need and mitigate risk.

7. Children subject to child in need and child protection plans, including disabled children, receive effective multi-agency interventions to address their needs and safety. Most social work practice is strong. Planning is effective and focuses on children's needs and risks. Children's circumstances are regularly reviewed through well-attended core group and child in need meetings. Social workers understand the impact of cumulative harm and chronic neglect on children. Appropriate information is shared at well-attended multi-agency meetings, and children's plans are updated so actions remain relevant and appropriately focused on children's needs. As a result, families access a range of specialist services, including substance misuse, domestic abuse and intensive family support, which are improving their lives.

8. Social workers know their children and families very well and build positive relationships with them. Children are seen regularly, and social work visits are purposeful and responsive to changes in children's needs, particularly if concerns arise. Social workers use a range of direct work tools and observations to engage children and understand their lived experiences, views, wishes and feelings. They use visits helpfully to inform children's plans and future planning.

9. Children's family networks are well considered in assessments, with some of the people included becoming active participants in children's planning. This

includes during pre-proceedings, when networks are brought together to determine the support that they can provide to children and their parents and to explore alternative care arrangements within their families if children cannot safely remain living with their parents.

10. For a small number of children, when their situations do not improve or risks escalate, timely and assertive action is not always taken to escalate to pre-proceedings or to initiate care proceedings. As a result, some children have been subjected to emergency action to keep them safe. For other children, this means that they do not enter care at a time that is right for them. This leaves some children in harmful situations for too long.

11. There are robust systems in place to identify and track children missing education, and the oversight of children who are electively home educated is strong. Highly effective systems and multi-agency collaboration ensure that leaders have an accurate understanding of the suitability of education children receive at home. If there are any reasons to believe that the home education provided is not suitable, the local authority acts swiftly to address this. Any safeguarding needs for children are identified and acted on.

12. There are robust tracking systems and multi-agency working is in place to ensure that children missing education are known to the local authority. Where appropriate, staff work closely with families and other professionals to find suitable provision, including alternative provision, to reintegrate children into education. When leaders use alternative provision, they complete the necessary checks to ensure that it is safe and will meet children's needs well.

13. Homeless 16- and 17-year-olds living in North Somerset receive a timely and robust response. Joint assessments between social care and housing are thorough and identify children's vulnerabilities, their family dynamics and needs. Support is tailored to meet children's assessed needs, which is supporting them to remain in their family networks. When needed, children are provided with immediate accommodation to prevent homelessness. Children understand their rights to be cared for, and for many children, this is their preferred option.

14. The response to children at risk of exploitation is underdeveloped. Risk assessments and safety planning for children are not always completed and updated. Despite this, social workers are tenacious in their efforts to understand risks and coordinate services through regular risk management meetings and strategy discussions to mitigate immediate risks to children. However, some children are not helped well enough by workers to recognise they are being harmed and remain vulnerable to exploitation. While the mapping of known associates is completed for most children to understand their networks, this is not leading to a coherent multi-agency response that reduces risk.

15. Children who go missing from home or care receive an inconsistent response. Return home conversations do not always take place, and when they do, there is insufficient focus on exploring push and pull factors so the right action can be taken to help reduce the likelihood of further occurrences.

16. A small number of children who have been identified as living in private fostering arrangements are supported and cared for well. Awareness-raising activities are being undertaken across the council area to help increase the identification of children living in private fostering arrangements.

17. Children who are young carers are recognised and receive appropriate help and support. Young carers can access a range of activities that support both their confidence and friendships, as part of the local authority's offer. When children are actively involved, young carer workers are positive advocates for them. They are proactive in involving themselves in multi-agency working, ensuring that children's needs and any vulnerabilities are raised in these forums. There is a waiting list for children to access this extended offer so not all children identified as young carers are receiving this specialist support.

18. The response to managing allegations of harm to children by people in a position of trust is not sufficiently robust. Immediate actions are coordinated by the local authority designated officer to keep children safe when allegations are made against professionals. However, follow-on actions are not always sufficiently timebound and the quality and consistency of information-sharing and recording are variable. This is leading to some drift and delay in reaching swift resolution when there are allegations against professionals.

19. For children on the edge of entering care when relationships within the family are fragile, highly skilled strengthening families workers provide intensive, tailored support to children and families. Workers take time to build relationships with children. They help their families understand their own experiences of parenting, recognise barriers and develop the tools needed to repair, rebuild and re-bond with their children. Work is well structured to cultivate parental aspirations, and targeted support helps them become the parents they want to be. This is helping to prevent concerns from escalating and some children entering care.

**The experiences and progress of children in care: good**

20. Children in care live in safe, stable and loving homes and are thriving and enjoying the full benefits of the support provided by their carers. Where possible, children are supported to be cared for within their wider networks by people who already know them. When this is not possible, most children live with suitable carers who are able to meet their needs.

21. Most assessments accurately capture children's needs and individual circumstances. Tenacious social workers consider children's childhood

experiences, inconsistencies in their care arrangements and childhood traumas and the impact these will have on their sense of self. Social workers are sensitive in their analysis of children's identity, including how children want to be viewed and the reasons behind this.

22. Children in care reviews are timely, and most are well attended by partners. Children are encouraged to attend and participate in their reviews. Children's plans are purposeful and aspirational and reflect children's voices, experiences and wishes well. Plans are regularly revisited and reviewed by independent safeguarding reviewing officers (ISROs). Following children's reviews, their ISROs write directly to children in a sensitive and child-friendly way so they have a record of what was discussed and of any key decisions made. This helps children to feel part of their care planning and that they are listened to and their wishes matter.

23. Most children leave care in a planned way and when this is in their best interests, following thorough assessments and having the support they need from their social workers. Children's safety, views, wishes and feelings are central to decision-making. This is ensuring that most children only remain in care for as long as necessary.

24. Social workers talk with genuine warmth, care and affection about their children. They build positive, trusting relationships with children and show a strong understanding of their needs, experiences and circumstances. Children are visited regularly. Social workers know their children and their histories well, showing a real interest in supporting them to make positive progress and to become the best version of themselves. Most children's records are written sensitively to the child, and for children.

25. Children are supported to build and maintain enduring relationships with people who are important in their lives, when it is safe to do so. Social workers are proactive in ascertaining children's views about family time and ensuring that these are central to decision-making and are reviewed regularly. When brothers and sisters do not live together, social workers make sure these relationships are maintained, or re-establish connections, whenever possible. This supports children to retain and develop a core part of their identity and relationships with people who are important to them.

26. Parents and other important adults are engaged and updated on changes in children's planning. They are invited and supported to attend children in care reviews, and their voices are considered in how children are cared for.

27. Social workers carry out direct work with children that is creative and age appropriate. They use a range of tools to help children understand their experiences and the reasons why they are in care. Many children benefit from life-story work to help them understand their journeys into care and beyond, but a small number of children do not have their life-story books completed.

28. Children in care benefit from having their physical health needs understood and met well. They are supported with their emotional needs by a dedicated practitioner while waiting to access specialist mental health support. For some children, this wait can be too long.

29. In North Somerset, the virtual school has clear oversight of the education children in care receive. Children are supported in their school attendance and educational attainment. They have personal education plans (PEPs) that are child centred and support improvement in their educational outcomes. There is some variability in the focus of targets in PEPs. Leaders are aware that further refinement is required to ensure that all targets are precise. The virtual school offers a wealth of professional learning opportunities for designated teachers to ensure they have the expertise they need. Attendance is a high priority, and robust processes ensure that children in care attend education regularly.

30. Children in care are supported to engage in activities and hobbies that interest them, such as clubs, sporting events, holidays, enrichment activities and concerts. This is supporting them to develop themselves, learn new things and engage in meaningful opportunities. Children in care are supported to access advocacy and an independent visitor when they need to.

31. Children in care benefit from living in stable and long-term homes with carers who can meet their needs. When children's care arrangements become unstable, concerted efforts are made by social workers to stabilise and maintain their living arrangements using wraparound services, including support from foster carers from the in-house fostering support arrangements. This helps children to feel increasingly secure in their relationships with carers and that they belong in their family.

32. There is a strong focus on achieving timely and effective permanence planning for children in care, including consideration of early permanence options for babies and younger children. Children's permanence plans are frequently monitored, tracked and reviewed at key points in their lives. Parallel and contingency plans are identified and, where possible, these plans are progressed. Practice strongly focuses on regularly reviewing and revisiting children's permanence plans to make sure the plan remains right for them, and all options, including reunification, are robustly explored and revisited when needed. Special guardianship orders are appropriately considered and progressed to give children stability and security away from the care system. For some children, the barriers to achieving special guardianship have not been overcome by the local authority, and some are not benefiting from the permanency this would give them.

33. The quality of assessment, planning and visits for children in care who live with their parents under placement with parents regulations is strong. When children return home in a planned way, detailed reunification assessments are

completed to aid decision-making and inform ongoing support. When children return to their parents in an unplanned way, social workers are proactive in responding to children's wishes and feelings. They update assessments, plans and support frameworks to ensure that the arrangements mitigate risk and children are suitably cared for.

34. Unaccompanied asylum-seeking children are well supported by committed and trauma-informed social workers who are sensitive to their cultural needs and their experiences. Social workers strive to match children with carers who are culturally aware and able to support them to access appropriate resources within their communities.

35. Disabled children in care and their carers receive tailored support from their social workers. Children's plans reflect their needs, risks and identities, as well as capturing their progress. Their additional needs and unique individual circumstances are well understood by their social workers. Transition planning for adulthood starts in a timely way and involves adult services at an early stage to support a smooth transition. This area of practice has significantly improved since the last focused visit.

36. When 16- and 17-year-olds are placed in registered supported accommodation, their needs are comprehensively considered before their move. Workers ensure they are ready and have the skills and maturity to take on more responsibility and to live more independently. When possible, they are given a choice of accommodation, empowering them to make decisions about where they want to live.

37. A small number of children live in unregistered children's homes. These are only used for children as a last resort, when registered options have been exhausted. There are robust and clear processes, lines of accountability, monitoring, scrutiny and oversight of the children and the quality of care they receive. This includes senior leaders visiting children placed in these illegal placements.

38. Assessment, approval and training of foster carers are strong in North Somerset. An established and well-understood fostering support model is developing and supporting an increasing number of foster carers, including kinship carers. Dedicated groups of carers are supporting other carers and children to develop and enhance support networks, and this is contributing to stability for more children. Children in care talked enthusiastically about holidays and days out with their carers and extended networks, as well as an opportunity to further develop the participation service they have called 'Patches'.

39. Strong working relationships between the regional adoption agency (RAA, Adoption West) and North Somerset focus on high-quality practice. The recruitment and assessment of prospective adopters by the RAA is positive,

with a targeted approach to recruitment. Additionally, adoption practice in the children in care service is strong, which is supporting children to be matched and placed with adopters at the earliest stage.

**The experiences and progress of care leavers: good**

40. Care leavers are cared for and cared about in North Somerset. Care leavers benefit from having consistent personal advisers (PAs) who know them well. This helps them to have their needs understood and to develop plans that meet their needs. Care leavers are supported well by tenacious PAs who are strong advocates for them. Most PAs are allocated early enough to build trusting relationships with the young people, and they develop an understanding of their support needs, worries and aspirations, as well as beginning to prepare them for independence and adulthood.

41. Care leavers are visited regularly by PAs, with the frequency of visits depending on their level of needs. Care leavers are seen in their homes as well as in places where they feel comfortable. Visits are tailored to meet the needs of individual care leavers. PAs use their understanding to create bespoke and thorough pathway plans, which they complete with care leavers. Potential risks are explored and safety planning is clearly informed by care leavers, so triggers and immediate actions are identified to keep them safer. Pathway plans are regularly reviewed and updated. This means that, for most care leavers, their plans meet their needs and are being progressed.

42. The local offer gives a wide range of practical and financial support to care leavers. PAs know the offer well and support young people to access their entitlements. Care leavers have the important documentation that they need to support their progress into adulthood and independence.

43. Most care leavers live in suitable accommodation. They are settled and feel safe in their homes and are well supported by their PAs, support staff and carers. When possible, and when this is in their best interests, care leavers are supported to remain with their previous foster carers under 'staying put' arrangements and to leave care without the pressure of moving out of their home. This gives young people more time to build confidence and to be ready to move towards independent living and adulthood. Care leavers who live in supported accommodation and independent accommodation are well supported by the PA and their life coaches in developing their independence skills. Most young people can access the financial support contained in the local offer to aid their independence, although some experience delays in accessing their leaving care grant. Leaders are aware of this and have taken action to address it.

44. Most care leavers have their physical needs met. However, they do not all have access to a dentist, and some have not had dental checks for a long time. Some care leavers can access timely counselling and therapy that supports them in making sense of some of the traumatic experiences they have had in childhood.

However, care leavers who need specialist mental health support experience significant delays in receiving it. Leaders are aware of this and have recently recruited an in-house psychologist to better support young people while they address this gap with health partners.

45. Care leavers' educational needs are well supported by the local authority. PAs work creatively with partners to support young people who are not in education, employment or training to ensure that they have access to opportunities and take up suitable options. Links with the local college and businesses support this process. Specialist support workers provide help to care leavers in creating CVs and with mock interviews and seeking employment. There is a joined-up approach from a range of agencies to support care leavers to access a range of education, employment and training opportunities.

46. Care leavers who are over 21 and allocated a PA receive a service that supports them, and they have their needs reviewed regularly. PAs are proactive in holding multi-agency meetings involving the young adult. This leads to a well-coordinated plan that supports their needs. Care leavers over 21 who choose to opt out of the service can access good support through both the care leavers' hub and the duty system. For most care leavers, if there are patterns of emerging or escalating need, then these are quickly identified, discussed with the young person and a PA reallocated. Also, regular reminders are sent to care leavers, keeping in touch and informing them of how to access the service.

47. Care leavers with additional needs are well supported in their transition to adulthood. PAs start to engage early with this group of care leavers and work alongside a dedicated transitions team. This specialist service ensures that care leavers do not fall between children's and adult services. They work jointly with PAs to review support packages as young people's skills develop. This means that young people's support packages remain pertinent to their level of need.

48. Former unaccompanied asylum-seeking care leavers receive high-quality support from their PAs. Their traumas and early life experiences are well understood, and tailored support is offered to meet their individual needs and circumstances. Most former unaccompanied asylum-seeking care leavers are making good progress. They are supported to learn English, engage in local community-based activities and helped to find their families. They are helped to access legal support to regularise their immigration status in the UK. Most are placed in suitable accommodation and are supported by a life skills coach to develop their independence skills. However, some former unaccompanied asylum-seeking care leavers experience either delay in their transition planning or a change of accommodation as they approach 18. This disrupts their ability to form a trusting relationship with their PA as well as disrupting the educational, social and friendship links that they may have established.

49. Care leavers who are parents are supported well. There is effective communication between their PA, children's social workers and health

professionals, and joint visits are undertaken to support expectant parents. Young people are well supported when their children are subject to statutory interventions by children's services. This means that most care leavers who are parents receive a well-coordinated package of support that involves a range of services.

50. The small number of care leavers who are in custody receive a variable service. For some, there is a lack of regular visits from their PA and a lack of robust multi-agency planning. This leads to some young people's needs not being met, both while in custody and on discharge from custody.

51. When care leavers are deemed vulnerable and at risk, there is strong multi-agency working to reduce the level of concern. For those care leavers who are vulnerable but resistant to help and support from the service, PAs are tenacious in trying to establish a relationship with them and provide the support they need.

**The impact of leaders on social work practice with children and families: good**

52. In 2023, inspectors judged the impact of leaders in North Somerset as 'requires improvement to be good'. Since then, confident and ambitious leaders have implemented significant changes to improve practice and services for children and their families. The DCS has been fundamental in influencing cultural change and partnership collaboration. They have prioritised the areas of practice identified as needing further improvements from previous inspections, focused visits and externally commissioned reviews. Along with improving core social work practice, support and services for disabled children, children in care and care leavers, new services have also been introduced. These include the harm outside of the home and strengthening families services, family group conferencing and the appointment of an in-house psychologist, although it is too soon to see the full impact of these changes.

53. Corporate and political leadership is a strength, and leaders are largely strong advocates for children. The governance arrangements mostly provide leaders with effective oversight of children's services. The chief executive has a strong understanding of children's services and maintains appropriate oversight of key areas of risks and strengths. Regular meetings between the DCS and the cabinet member for children's services ensure sustained scrutiny and accountability, complemented by quarterly engagement with elected members, including the council leader and the chief executive.

54. There has been significant financial investment in children's services to meet children and young people's needs, particularly in relation to addressing placement sufficiency. Over the last 2 years, leaders have had a positive impact on the use of unregistered children's homes and have substantially reduced the number of children living in these settings. Almost all children in care now live

in registered placements, which is a significant improvement since the last inspection. Leaders are also acutely aware that a small number of children live in settings that are not aligned to their needs because of a lack of foster placements, and there has been a renewed focus by leaders on this aspect of sufficiency. As a result, positive progress has been made to increase the number of foster carers and strengthen the support provided to carers through the implementation of the fostering support model. Tangible and realistic plans are also in place and underway to open 2 new children's homes and to improve the offer of short breaks for disabled children.

55. The local authority's self-evaluation is largely accurate and self-challenging, and most areas closely align with the findings of this inspection. There are a small number of discrete practice areas that need further attention, which had not been identified by leaders. Leaders have been receptive to these findings and are taking steps to address these shortfalls.

56. The corporate parenting strategy has recently been refreshed and provides clarity on how the local authority meets its corporate parenting responsibilities. Although the corporate parenting panel is well established and has good attendance by partners, there are gaps in fully supporting some children in care and care leavers in some specific areas of their needs. This includes housing options for some care leavers, dental and mental health care. Although children and young people attend and participate in corporate parenting panel, their impact in influencing support and services is less evident.

57. Leaders have mature and effective strategic relationships with safeguarding partners and are able to challenge each other when required, using the escalation processes. The chief executive is actively involved in safeguarding partnership arrangements and provides strong leadership across the wider partnership for children. This includes chairing the corporate parenting operational group and the children and young people's partnership board, strengthening whole-council and partnership ownership of responsibilities for children. Working alongside the DCS, they have helped to improve, for example, the timeliness of strategy discussions and child protection enquiries, so children are receiving a quicker response when they need help and protection.

58. There is a wide-ranging programme of quality assurance that is helping leaders to identify areas of practice that need further improvement. While some audits, known as collaborative practice reviews, are over optimistic, the moderation process is strong, and this helps to identify weaknesses. Speedy remedial work is taken to address shortfalls in practice. Managers and leaders use data intelligently to identify themes and any emerging deterioration in service delivery and take decisive action. Effective quality assurance and performance management information are helping leaders to assure themselves of the quality of practice as well as wider organisational learning.

59. Leaders have made good progress in improving workforce stability and have successfully reduced the over-reliance on agency staff since the last inspection. Improvements in training and recruitment and retention, including 'grow your own' and international recruitment, are helping social workers build and sustain positive relationships with their children and improve the lives of vulnerable children, young people and families.

60. Staff enjoy working in North Somerset and feel well supported by their managers and senior leaders. Morale is high, despite some staff understandably feeling a little apprehensive about the organisational changes and wider restructuring that is happening. Staff feel involved, engaged and consulted on the changes and feel valued, respected and highly motivated in their roles. Organisational culture, leadership visibility and values are consistent strengths in North Somerset.

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